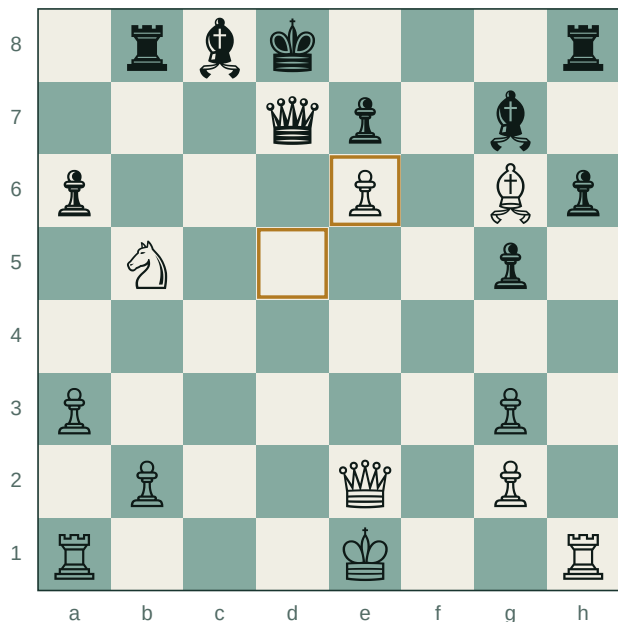


Active defensive resources: Black, move 23

Active defensive resources

Black to move



Previous move: 23.dxe6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

23...Qxb5 24. Qd2+ Kc7 25. Rc1+ Kb7 26. Be4+ Ka7

23...Qxb5 The queen captures the knight on b5. Recorded reply: **24.Qd2+**.

24...Kc7 The king moves from d8 to c7. Recorded reply: **25.Rc1+**.

25...Kb7 The king moves from c7 to b7. Recorded reply: **26.Be4+**.

26...Ka7 The king moves from b7 to a7.

At the end, nominal material is White 27 / Black 29 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on e1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on g6 and rook on h1. Check for tactical protection.